

From the Ground Up: Inside a Grassroots Psychedelic Conference

A report from the Psychonauticon Conference in Brno

I really love Vienna. For me, living for almost half a year without leaving a conservative, monumental city is not difficult at all. I swear. Not a word of a lie.

For exactly this reason, when I received a message from a good acquaintance about a psychedelic conference in the Czech Republic, I didn't even wait for his active invitation. You know, they say that our brain (soul, ego, essence, or whatever else it might be) knows our next actions long before we consciously process them? Well. I knew right away that by the end of November, I would be in the small city of Brno, surrounded by people I had never met. A quick search on a simple but stylish website called Psychonauticon2025, and the slogan immediately caught my eye: "Join us for an inspiring gathering at the intersection of science, culture, and consciousness." Beautiful — and somehow confusingly abstract. But I love adventures — and, as it will turn out later, it was not for nothing that I was drawn so strongly to this one.

The bureaucracy was resolved simply, though slowly: correspondence with a frequency of one email every seven working days. I couldn't help but feel sentimental about this familiar classic — the organizational tempo of small events held together only by volunteers and a good portion of pure goodwill. In the end, for being added to some kind of ephemeral list of approved participants, I paid around 35 euros for two days. An incredible offer for an event that could potentially change my understanding of reality. How can you even try to measure abstract potential gains in the form of knowledge, connections, emotions, and insights using a shaky capitalist unit of value?

But what kind of conference is this, exactly? Digging a little deeper, I find the first major hook: *this special event will celebrate the upcoming psilocybin scientific trials in the Czech Republic, set to begin next year*. Now I feel the emotional contours of the trip beginning to take shape. I closely follow the development of the legal status of psychedelics — and oh boy, we do have some reasons to celebrate. Apart from Australia and Switzerland, long considered progressive, some U.S. states have followed suit, allowing licensed psilocybin services for adults over 21 in supervised environments. Unexpectedly, in March 2025 Ukrainian Ministry of Health laid the foundation for scientific research with psychedelics, aiming toward evidence-based policy and allowing medical treatment for veterans and civilians recovering from war trauma. Now we just need to reschedule the drugs from the most restrictive category — easy-peasy (we as in we, Ukrainians). A bit later in June 2025, New Zealand approved the prescription of medicinal psilocybin for treating treatment-resistant

depression. And now — the Czech Republic joins in as well. Each and every event — it's own reason to celebrate. Thus It's good that the schedule includes not only lectures, but also parties. Two of them, to be precise — on Saturday and on Sunday. "An interesting choice," I think to myself, and continue browsing the website.

"...in partnership with PsychedeliCare" — the second hook. I know this organization, and I even once applied to volunteer with them. Founded in 2023 by Théo Giubilei, a French guy based in Brussels with a background in European politics. Today, the organization has more than 400 members across over 20 countries (as they state on their website; but some of them are my dear friends, so I do believe in those numbers). In 2024, PsychedeliCare officially registered a European Citizens' Initiative calling for safe regulated access to psychedelic-assisted therapy and for support of scientific research freed of cultural stigma. This idea was met with great appreciation from many "old-school" respected activist psychedelic organizations, such as PAREA, PsychedelicsEurope, and the Psychedelics French Society — in other words, *one for all and all for one*: PsychedeliCare was positively recognized within the circle of psychedelic grassroots organizations.

Well, you can never prepare enough for a conference, and using this excuse, I don't even try — I decide to let everything else just drift. Whatever happens, happens. Just two hours from my doorstep, and I'm at the train station in Brno, a city that, after Vienna, feels like a breath of fresh air and draws you in with its honesty and simplicity. An almost esoteric place of power, a small free city — one of the centres of activity of the Theosophical Society in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. A city that is just a stone's throw away from a clinic where psychiatrist Milan Hausner (1929–2000) actively used LSD in individual and group psychotherapy long before it became mainstream — back in the days of Czechoslovakia, in the 1960s and 1970s. A clinic where he conducted more than 3,000 sessions. One of the most experienced and remarkable advocates of psychedelic use. The clinic is still operating — and has 4.1 stars from 17 Google reviews, one of which simply reads: "very romantic place."

I walk admiring the small streets, parks, wrought-iron fences that seem to speak Czech; when right next to me, behind a woven fence, appears a sight — half dump, half abstraction: a pile of boards, pieces of wood, someone's jacket, one boot, and something that seems to have once been a baby stroller. In short, incredibly conceptual picture. "This could have been a pavilion at the Viennale," I think to myself without a trace of irony. "But come on — could it really...? No way!" Right next to it, a very low, formerly purely technical building suddenly emerges, now painted in an exquisitely modern, liberally purple colour. I check Google Maps and undoubtedly, I am exactly at the appointed place. How else could it be. Piled up, cluttered with abandoned objects, hidden from view, concealed beneath heaps of wood, beneath the urban history of the city, a space for hidden, occult knowledge (*Latin: occulere* —

to cover over, conceal, hide). “Ring,” says the word on the wall, and right next to it, for clarity, an arrow is drawn pointing to the doorbell. For a second, I feel like Alice, and gathering the courage to become either taller or smaller, I ring.

The door was opened to me by a flustered-looking guy, clearly not very happy that I had rung the bell — no surprise, I’m at least three hours late. He disappears somewhere into a maze of corridors, and I follow the trail he leaves behind like the White Rabbit, finding myself in a space where I am immediately washed over by a sense of shared values. Just like that, right from the threshold. Simply from the fact that not a single head turned in my direction when the door creaked as I entered, but instead, almost enchanted — or rather, “as if not from this reality” — everyone remained intensely focused on the podium. From the stage, the words were heard:

The ceiling was very low — and in the best traditions of contemporary spaces for contemporary free people, who were already seated on stylish wooden chairs in front of a low podium with a chair for the presenter. The sense of freedom lived in the self-made (and partly unfinished) design — no wallpaper, walls covered with pages torn out of books; a PVC kitchen; a refrigerator that has probably seen more parties than I have in my entire life; draped fabrics in the style of a psytrance gatherings; and, of course, a board with four clocks — London, Shanghai, New York, and Tokyo. All of them turned upside down, and to my great disappointment, not a single one was working. This eclectic mix of styles, although slightly disorienting at first, had one undeniable advantage — it suited everyone present, and everyone present suited it. As I later found out, this place was chosen “in a last-minute despair — and also it’s grungy and underground, exactly as I like it,” the organizer said. “I was very happy, because I am always looking for new sexy locations.”

For these two days, presenters gathered from five countries: a bunch of PhD researchers, practical investigators, independent proactive activists, and artists. It turned into a vivid tapestry of topics — from years of therapeutic practice and historical perspectives on esotericism and occultism, through the practical use of psychedelics in journalism, a.k.a. gonzo journalism, to a conceptual exploration of philosophical narratives. Everything scientific, everything grounded. Yet all the researchers officially came from different fields — some universities had pushed the topic of psychedelics into a philosophy department, some into anthropology, others into psychology, and some even into a faculty of religious studies. I guess, it’s only logical — how can one possibly taxonomize such an all-encompassing matter?

Previously when I’ve spoken with people outside the circle interested in psychedelics, the idea of “being alternative” often surfaced in conversations. Alternative thinking, alternative movements, alternative knowledge. And this gathering at first also felt somehow alternative — and for me personally, that would be not a very positive description. I have always had a question: how can a movement position itself as

being “against” something? As an alternative to something? In this way, self-positioning does not emerge from within, but from the necessity of having something to oppose — and therefore, after the disappearance of that something, it holds the potential for a deafening collapse. Yet after a few hours, I stopped seeing the surface-level “alternativeness” and began to see substance and cohesion. This cohesion seemed to come from within a shared, grounded philosophical understanding, rather than from the presence of a common enemy outside. That is how it happens — cohesion within society at some point grows, swells, passes a certain mathematical percentage — and ceases to be “alternative,” even for a broader audience.

After the first block of lectures — the first long break. Outside it is wet and cold, yet in the courtyard an iron bathtub stacked with logs is already prepared. Someone tries to start a fire; it absolutely refuses to catch. Yet even without life-giving fire, conversations unfold around its placeholder. There are spaces and encounters where small talk is not needed. When from the very first words you feel unexpectedly safe yet are being intensely and directly asked about yourself — about something essential. When the social tango of surface conversations is consciously skipped, the one during which you are supposed to determine whether you share a common vision. In this space, the invitation was immediately toward exchange for insights, for change. It was surprisingly simple and unspeakably complex at the same time. To my own surprise, I caught myself thinking that this space felt like one of the most intimate gatherings I had ever been to.

On the evening of the first day, during the announced party, I managed to catch the ever-elusive Tancredi, the main organizer. He is a vivid representative of that type of person you see for the first time, yet you have a persistent feeling that you have already lived through several wild stories together that bonded you forever. He, a Ph.D. researcher in Religious Studies at Masaryk University Brno, a part of PsychedeliCare Network, and a cool guy, completely immersed himself in his role of a small conference host.

“What was I thinking, putting parties into the schedule for both days — Saturday and Sunday?” he said, laughing.

I wasn’t going to waste time. I had questions. Many questions.

“The reason for this event? I just wanted to shake off academia; often the way knowledge is presented during scientific conferences is boring and not that immersive; the way it happens now is that people just talk dryly from a stage — and not always successfully. My goal is to put humanity back into humanity studies”.

When asked why he decided to organize Psychonauticon now, Tancredi didn’t hesitate: “Many people in the field of psychedelic research don’t know what to do with their studies — whereas I decided to use my knowledge and try to put something

together and most importantly to do it exactly the way I like it. I believe in the transcendent value of research on psychedelics.”

From his own words, he managed to build a bit of a weirdo reputation by investing in conferences, travelling, and networking rather than publishing papers; this approach made his own conference possible - the fellow researchers he connected with over the years, upon invitation simply decided to gamble on taking part in Psychonauticon.

“Funding came entirely out of my own pocket. Luckily enough, I broke even,” he laughed. “Overall, it was just a race I decided to jump into — because I felt that if I don’t start it now, I’ll never do it.”

The second day was no less intense. It began with a trip to the forest for a morning meditation and connection with nature. “Take a deep breath. Listen to the sounds around you — the rustling leaves and the birds singing.” Yet around us it was very quiet; only a dog was barking very loudly. I slowly breathed in, calm, but a bit excited for the lectures ahead. Then we returned to the now already familiar space, and a new portion of input for reflection awaited us — new conversations, new insights.

But I won’t describe everything in detail, because that would turn into a small novel of its own. Still, these two days left me with a new and rather fundamental question. What is a psychedelic experience? Could all of this be it? Are all of us — all 40 participants of the first conference of its kind in Brno — are part of what we are studying? A fractal beginning with itself and spiralling inward. And the understanding that, despite the small size, perhaps a bit of eccentricity, perhaps a lot of dust and slightly too much psychedelic paraphernalia, we — there and then— were part of a broader social current around psychedelics.

Ironically enough, also here the society seems to have come full circle: from around 10,000 scientific publications between 1943 and 1970 — enough for psychedelics to be described as “the most intensively researched pharmacological substance ever” by Oxford University Press — through moral panic and prohibition. One of many telling examples is the Vancouver School Board’s 1967 bulletin “*Dangers of LSD*”, warning that “case histories show a slipping in achievement in every phase of life” among LSD users. This narrative eventually led to classification as a Schedule I drug and the beginning of the war on drugs. And now, once again, we are looping back: a renewed popular movement, the creation of organizations, the registration of a European initiative in 2024, and a growing number of articles in international journals on the topic since the early 2000s.

According to researcher Bendeck Sotillos, the contemporary discourse around psychedelics often carries distinctly utopian features: many see these substances as a panacea; 91% of psychologists, according to one study, considered therapy using them under supervised conditions entirely safe. At the same time, technologists

dream of creating “superbeings” and are developing a movement of transhumanism — combining psychedelics and technology. This, in turn, is by no means a new idea, but traces back to one of the pioneers of psychedelics, American psychologist and counterculture advocate Timothy Leary (1920–1996).

Yet our time can also be described as a wave of spiritual nihilism confronting Western civilization. It is therefore not surprising that this growing interest to spirituality and “hidden” ways back to the roots also evolves into the phenomenon of psychedelic capitalism — when those who possess resources attempt to fill the vacuum created by the culture’s crisis of meaning. Many industry leaders who have taken an interest in producing the next generation of psychedelics seek to secure intellectual property rights. The psychedelic field has already become a dizzying marketplace for mass consumption, offering an excess of publications, podcasts, festivals, nonprofit organizations, conferences, self-proclaimed gurus, resort centres, and exclusive retreats catering to elite clientele.

And what can one say — even academic conferences on psychedelics are heavily monetized. While writing this article, I conducted a small experiment: in 30 minutes, I found 12 on-site psychedelic conferences across seven different countries. Two of them, curiously enough, are taking place in New Orleans at the same time. Tickets range from 400 euros to 2,000 euros per participant. Research is good, I know. But these large conferences with prices above 450 euros certainly feel like a form of gatekeeping.

And while biotechnology start-ups are already raising substantial capital for clinical trials, with both investors and venture capitalists scoping possible multibillion-dollar mass-market profits, it is crucial to remain open to discourse for the sake of simple, everyday curiosity. To research, to talk, to be interested, and to share — not because it is necessary for some bigger purpose, not because it is profitable, and not because it will heal the world — but because it is, quite simply and very humanly, interesting. It is precisely at such small conferences that the hidden everyday magic of psychedelics is kept alive. So, if we are already learning to approach ecology, climate, and mental health consciously, we should also approach the cultural discourse on psychedelics with the same awareness — beginning at the grassroots level.